

TOPIC 4: GOVERNMENT INSTITUTIONS

1. The Three Arms of Government

In a democracy, government power is usually divided among three arms so that no single person or group holds all power.

2. The Executive

The executive implements and enforces laws and runs the day-to-day government. At the federal level in Nigeria it is headed by the President (and includes ministers, the civil service and security agencies). At the state level it is headed by the Governor.

3. The Legislature

The legislature makes laws. At the federal level Nigeria has a National Assembly (Senate and House of Representatives). States have Houses of Assembly. The legislature also debates policy, approves budgets and can check the executive.

4. The Judiciary

The judiciary interprets the law and settles disputes. It includes courts from the Supreme Court down to lower courts. An independent judiciary protects rights and ensures that government and citizens obey the law.

5. Functions and Checks

Each arm has distinct functions. They also check one another (e.g. the legislature can pass laws and oversee the executive; the judiciary can declare laws or actions unconstitutional). This system of checks and balances supports good governance.

6. Summary

Government institutions comprise the executive (implements), legislature (makes laws) and judiciary (interprets). Separation of powers and checks and balances help prevent abuse of power.

End of Topic 4